

Schism, Censure, and the War for the Soul of the Faithful

The Two Fires

An Expansion for Fate's Edge

Under the lamp, bread and salt — the flame witnesses both sides

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A Note on Method

This expansion was written in a candle-lit scriptorium in Thepyrgos, on paper that had been used to wrap heretical pamphlets. The ink is lamp-black and the ash of a burned confession. The author is a convert who has worn both collars and will not say which fire she chose.

The Everflame and the Temple of Light share the same Patrons. They recite similar prayers. They light similar candles.

They are not the same faith.

One is the state religion of an empire. One is the hedge-court faith of a fractured kingdom. One burns heretics at the stake. One burns them in effigy and calls it rehabilitation.

This expansion is not a polemic. It is a ledger. Both sides owe debts. Both sides have paid in blood. The reader is not asked to choose. The reader is asked to witness.

Part I

The Two Fires

Chapter 1 Working Title and Core Concept

1.1 The Schism in Brief

The Everflame and the Temple of Light were once the same faith. The rupture occurred during the Utaran succession crisis, when the High Auditor of Ecktoria declared that the flame could not be carried across the mountains without losing its purity. The Synod of Thepyrgos responded that purity was not the point—illumination was.

Three centuries later, neither side remembers the original argument. They remember the burnings.

1.2 What Both Faiths Share

- The same three Patrons: OATH OF FLAME & LIGHT, INQUISITOR PRIME, OATH OF MERCY AND GRACE.
- The same sacred texts (though the Everflame uses a redacted edition and the Temple uses a glossed edition).
- The same prayers (recited in different orders, with different emphases).
- The same enmities (Malachai cults, Daughters of the Cord, unsanctioned magic).

1.3 What Divides Them

Aspect	Everflame (Ecktoria)	Temple of Light (Viterra/Thepyrgos)
Nature of the divine	Flame: consuming, purifying, juridical	Light: illuminating, refracting, pastoral
Relation to state	Imperial religion	Civic religion with exemptions
Heresy	Crime against the empire	Crime against the soul
Treatment of heretics	Execution (stake)	Rehabilitation (re-education)
Attitude to magic	Unsanctioned magic = heresy	Unsanctioned magic = mental illness
Inquisitorial arm	Flame-Wardens	Chain-Lanterns
Attitude to children with talent	Burn the taint	Conscript the child

1.4 What This Expansion Adds

- Doctrinal depth for both faiths, making them playable and morally complex.
- The Chain-Lanterns as a full faction, including their conscription of children with arcane talent.
- New Talents for characters sworn to either Order (or caught between them).
- The Ninth Citation—a forbidden passage that both faiths suppressed and heretics whisper.

- A campaign frame set in a border region where the Two Fires compete for souls.

Part II

The Everflame

Chapter 2 History: The Imperial Fire

2.1 Origins in the Utaran Forge

The Everflame began as a cult of the imperial forge—a belief that the fire which shaped Utaran steel also shaped the empire’s soul. When the empire fell, the cult survived, carried by soldiers who had prayed before battle and by smiths who had lit candles for safe hammer-strikes.

Ecktoria adopted the Everflame as its state religion during the Consolidation Wars. The Grand Magistrate’s argument was simple:

A kingdom without a single flame is a kingdom of shadows.

2.2 The Great Purge (Year 312 AR)

The first systematic suppression of unsanctioned magic. The Flame-Wardens were established. Hundreds were burned. The Codex of Illumination was redacted to remove references to the Ninth Citation. The Temple of Light, then still a reform movement within the Everflame, protested. The protest was ignored.

2.3 The Schism (Year 478 AR)

The Synod of Thepyrgos declared independence, citing the Everflame’s corruption by imperial politics. The Grand Magistrate declared the Synod heretical. Both sides excommunicated each other. Neither side has rescinded the excommunication.

Chapter 3 Doctrine: Truth and Measure Are One

3.1 The Flame as Witness

The Everflame teaches that fire remembers. A candle lit in testimony cannot be extinguished until the truth is spoken. A heretic burned at the stake does not die—they become ash-witnesses, their testimony preserved in the smoke.

The flame does not judge. The flame witnesses. The judge is the empire.

3.2 Confession and Censure

Confession must be public. The priest lights a candle. The penitent speaks. The candle burns. If the candle gutters before the confession ends, the confession is incomplete—the penitent must return.

Censure is public and permanent. A heretic's name is struck from the parish registry. Their family may not pray for them. Their ashes are scattered beyond the city walls.

3.3 The Three Orders

- **OATH OF FLAME & LIGHT**: Warriors and crusaders. The flame is a weapon.
- **INQUISITOR PRIME (FLAME-WARDENS)**: Prosecutors and executioners. The flame purges.
- **OATH OF MERCY AND GRACE (HOSPITALIERS)**: Healers and confessors. The flame comforts.

Chapter 4 Hierarchy: The Grand Magistrate's Seal

4.1 The Grand Magistrate

Elected by the High Synod of Ecktoria. Serves for life or until removed for heresy. The current Grand Magistrate, His Eminence Varrus the Steadfast, has held the seal for forty-two years.

4.2 The Flame-Wardens

The inquisitorial arm. They wear iron masks and carry censers that smoke with blessed coal. Their authority extends to any territory claimed by Ecktoria. They answer only to the Grand Magistrate.

4.3 The Censorate

Bureaucrats who review confessions, maintain heretical registries, and approve burnings. A Censor can delay an execution indefinitely—or expedite it. They are the most feared office in the Everflame because they are the least visible.

Chapter 5 Practices: The Candle and the Stake

5.1 The Candle Test

A suspected heretic is seated in a room with a single candle. A priest asks questions. The candle's behavior is observed: steady flame = truth; guttering = deception; extinguishing = demonic possession. The test has no empirical validity. Its results have sent hundreds to the stake.

5.2 The Unspoken Ninth Citation

A procedural loophole. If a heretic's confession cannot be obtained, the Flame-Warden may cite the Ninth Citation—a redacted passage that permits execution without confession. The citation is never spoken aloud. It is merely noted in the ledger.

Chapter 6 Relationship to Patrons

6.1 Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)

The warrior's path. Everflame adherents emphasize the flame's consuming nature. They pray for the strength to burn corruption. Their Rites grant +1 die against heretics and +1 Harm against unsanctioned magic users.

6.2 Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutors)

The judge's path. Everflame inquisitors view the Inquisitor Prime as a divine prosecutor. Their Rites grant +1 die to detect lies and +1 Effect when sentencing the guilty.

6.3 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitaliers, Watched)

The healer's path—but watched. Everflame healers must report any heretic they treat. A confessor who shields a heretic from justice is herself a heretic. The Order of Mercy and Grace has produced more martyrs than any other.

Part III

The Temple of Light

Chapter 7 History: The Hedge-Law Faith

7.1 Born from the Margins

The Temple of Light began as a reform movement within the Everflame—priests who argued that the flame had become a tool of imperial control rather than a source of illumination. They were excommunicated. They did not recant.

7.2 The Viterran Refuge

Viterra's hedge-law kingdom offered sanctuary. The Temple established a synod, built schools, and began translating the Codex of Illumination into the common tongue. The faith spread through evangelism, not conquest.

7.3 The Chain-Lanterns' Founding

As the Temple grew, so did the threat of unsanctioned magic. The Synod authorized an inquisitorial order—the Chain-Lanterns—to investigate and rehabilitate. Unlike the Everflame's Flame-Wardens, the Chain-Lanterns were not permitted to execute. They found loopholes.

Chapter 8 Doctrine: Light as Lens

8.1 The Refraction of the Divine

The Temple teaches that the divine is not a single flame but a spectrum. It refracts into three aspects:

- **Gold (Justice):** *The light that exposes wrongdoing.*
- **Silver (Truth):** *The light that reveals what is hidden.*
- **White (Mercy):** *The light that forgives.*

No single aspect is complete without the others.

8.2 Confession and Rehabilitation

Confession is private. The penitent speaks to a priest in a candle-lit room. The priest does not report what is heard. The goal is not punishment but reintegration. Heretics are not burned. They are re-educated. The Temple maintains sanctuaries where the possessed and the wayward are taught to control their gifts. Some leave. Most do not.

Chapter 9 Hierarchy: The Synod and the Chain

9.1 The Synod

A council of bishops, abbots, and lay scholars. Meets twice yearly in Thepyrgos. Elects the Archon of Light, who serves as spiritual leader but has no temporal authority.

9.2 The Dawn-Knights

Warriors who protect pilgrims, guard sanctuaries, and—when necessary—hunt rogue magic users. Unlike the Everflame’s crusaders, the Dawn-Knights are forbidden from initiating violence. They may only respond.

9.3 The Chain-Lanterns

The Temple’s inquisitorial arm. They carry iron lanterns on chains—the flame is visible, the chain is a reminder of restraint. They investigate, detain, and rehabilitate. They are also the Temple’s spies, assassins, and secret police.

Chapter 10 Practices: The Bell and the Mirror

10.1 The Bell-Toll Ordeal

A suspect is placed in a chamber with a single bell. They must answer questions. Each lie causes the bell to ring—or so the suspect is told. The bell is rung by a hidden Chain-Lantern. The ordeal has no empirical validity. Its results have sent hundreds to re-education.

10.2 The White Mirror

A polished silver surface used to detect unsanctioned magic. A mage who looks into the mirror sees their own reflection—but the reflection is slightly delayed. The longer the delay, the more dangerous the mage. The mirror is not magical. The mirror is a prop. The Chain-Lanterns' judgment is the only test that matters.

Chapter 11 Relationship to Patrons

11.1 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn-Knights)

The warrior's path—but the Temple emphasizes protection, not destruction. Dawn-Knights pray for the strength to shield the innocent. Their Rites grant +1 die when defending another and +1 Armor when protecting a sanctuary.

11.2 Inquisitor Prime (Chain-Lanterns)

The judge's path—but the Temple emphasizes investigation, not sentencing. Chain-Lanterns pray for the patience to find the truth. Their Rites grant +1 die to detect lies and +1 Effect when exposing corruption.

11.3 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitallers)

The healer's path—and the Temple gives them autonomy. Hospitallers may treat anyone, regardless of faith or crime. They are not required to report what they hear. This autonomy has produced the Temple's most beloved saints—and its most dangerous secrets.

Part IV

The Chain-Lanterns

Chapter 12 The Temple's Sword and Shadow

12.1 History of the Order

Founded during the Viterran witch-panics of the seventh century. The Synod needed an inquisitorial arm that could investigate without provoking the hedge-courts. The Chain-Lanterns were that arm.

Initially, they were respected. They exposed genuine conspiracies and saved innocents from mob justice. Over time, their methods grew more aggressive. The chain that symbolized restraint became a weapon.

12.2 Methods and Tools

- ***The Candle-Smoke Test:*** *A suspect breathes over a candle. The smoke's color indicates guilt—or so the Chain-Lanterns claim. The test's results are predetermined.*
- ***The Bell-Toll Ordeal:*** *Described above. The Chain-Lanterns have perfected the timing.*
- ***The White Mirror:*** *Described above. A prop that has never failed to produce a confession.*

12.3 Conscription of Children

The Temple's most controversial practice. Children with arcane talent are identified—often through the Chain-Lanterns' network of informants—and taken to sanctuaries for "rehabilitation." Most never leave. Some become Chain-Lanterns themselves.

12.4 Secret Operations in Ecktoria

The Chain-Lanterns operate illegally in Everflame territory, hunting "heretics" who have fled Temple justice. The Everflame's Flame-Wardens know. They have cooperated—and clashed. The Chain-Lanterns have a safehouse in Ecktoria's cat-combs. Its location is a secret the Everflame would kill to learn.

Part V

The Shared Patrons

Chapter 13 Oath of Flame & Light: The Warrior's Path

13.1 Everflame Interpretation: The Flame Is a Weapon

The Everflame's warriors see themselves as instruments of divine judgment. They are crusaders. They do not negotiate with heresy. They burn it.

13.2 Temple Interpretation: The Light Is a Guide

The Temple's Dawn-Knights see themselves as shields. They protect the innocent. They do not seek out heresy—they wait for it to reveal itself.

13.3 The Schism Within

The shared Order is riven by the Two Fires. A Dawn-Knight who refuses to burn a heretic is a coward to the Everflame. A crusader who burns a village is a monster to the Temple. Neither side is entirely wrong.

13.4 New Talents

13.4.1 Radiant Vow (Everflame, 6 XP)

Swear an oath before a flame. While keeping the oath, gain +1 die to all actions. Breaking the oath causes 2 Harm (the flame's rebuke). The oath's terms must be specific and achievable.

13.4.2 Dawn's Shield (Temple, 6 XP)

Once per session, interpose yourself to protect an innocent. Convert any Harm they would have taken into Fatigue for yourself. The innocence must be genuine—the shield does not protect the guilty.

13.4.3 Candle-Knight (Hybrid, 10 XP)

*You have studied both traditions. Once per session, you may invoke either faith's interpretation of a shared Rite, but you gain a *Split Loyalty* [6] timer. When it fills, you must choose a side. Refusal is heresy to both.*

Chapter 14 Inquisitor Prime: The Judge's Path

14.1 Everflame Interpretation: The Flame-Wardens

Prosecutors who burn corruption. They are not investigators—they are executioners. Their authority is absolute within Everflame territory.

14.2 Temple Interpretation: The Chain-Lanterns

Investigators who expose heresy. They are not executioners—they detain and rehabilitate. Their authority is constrained by Synod oversight.

14.3 The Schism Within

The shared Order is a cold war. Flame-Wardens view Chain-Lanterns as fanatics who have forgotten that mercy is a virtue. Chain-Lanterns view Flame-Wardens as state-sponsored murderers. They have cooperated against common enemies. They have also framed each other for heresy.

14.4 New Talents

14.4.1 Flame-Warden's Brand (Everflame, 8 XP)

Mark a heretic. For one session, you know their location (as long as they remain within the same region). They suffer -1 die to resist your social rolls. The brand is visible to other Flame-Wardens.

14.4.2 Chain-Lantern's Bell (Temple, 8 XP)

Ring a bell. For one scene, any unsanctioned magic within Near must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) or be revealed—the caster's location, the spell's nature, and the caster's face. The bell's note carries. Witnesses will know something happened.

14.4.3 The Ninth Citation (Heresy, 12 XP)

You have read the forbidden passage. Once per session, you may invoke it to gain +2 dice on any roll—but both faiths will hunt you. The citation cannot be used twice in the same location. The Unspoken notices repetition.

Chapter 15 Oath of Mercy and Grace: The Healer's Path

15.1 Everflame Interpretation: Mercy Is Earned

The Everflame's Hospitaliers heal heretics—but they must report them. A heretic who receives care and does not confess is returned to the Flame-Wardens. The healing is not free. The debt must be paid.

15.2 Temple Interpretation: Mercy Is Given

The Temple's Hospitallers heal anyone, regardless of faith or crime. They are not required to report. The healing is free. The only debt is gratitude—and gratitude is not tracked in ledgers.

15.3 The Schism Within

The shared Order is a battlefield of conscience. Everflame Hospitaliers who shield heretics are martyrs. Temple Hospitallers who report heretics are traitors. The same action, judged by different fires, produces opposite verdicts.

15.4 New Talents

15.4.1 Confessional Seal (Everflame, 4 XP)

You cannot be magically compelled to reveal a confession. You also cannot break a confidence voluntarily without marking 1 Fatigue. The seal is absolute. Break it, and the flame will remember.

15.4.2 Unburdened Healing (Temple, 4 XP)

When you heal someone, you may choose not to report them (even if your faith requires it). Mark 1 Fatigue if you conceal a heretic. The fatigue is the weight of the secret.

15.4.3 The Ninth Prayer (Heresy, 12 XP)

You have learned to heal without conditions—no confession, no reporting, no debt. Each time you use this talent, mark 1 Corruption. The Unspoken is watching. The Unspoken is pleased.

Part VI

The Quiet War

Chapter 16 The Battle for the Mistlands

Both faiths compete for souls in the Mistlands. The Everflame sends missionaries with guards. The Temple sends Dawn-Knights disguised as pilgrims. The locals accept the medicine and burn the pamphlets.

16.1 New Faction: The Gray Pilgrims

Neutral healers who accept aid from both faiths and convert to neither. They are respected by the Mistlanders and distrusted by both churches. A Gray Pilgrim who accepts healing from the Everflame must also accept a lecture on sin. A Gray Pilgrim who accepts grain from the Temple must also accept a child's catechism.

16.2 New Threat: The Chain-Lanterns "Investigating"

The Chain-Lanterns have begun operating in the Mistlands, hunting witches who may be midwives with herb gardens. The Everflame views this as an incursion. The Mistlanders view it as terrorism. The Chain-Lanterns view it as justice.

Chapter 17 The Linn Crusade

The Temple sends no armies to Linn—only teachers, healers, and grain. The Linn accept the grain. The children learn to read the Codex of Illumination. The old shrines fall silent.

17.1 New Faction: The Shrine-Devout

Linn who resist conversion. They keep the old shrines, light the old candles, and whisper the old names. The Temple views them as obstacles. The Everflame views them as pagans. The Shrine-Devout view themselves as the last witnesses.

17.2 New Mechanic: Faith Pressure [6]

A regional timer that ticks as the Temple gains influence. Advances when the Temple builds a school, converts a chieftain, or baptizes a child. Retreats when the Shrine-Devout reclaim a sacred site, expose a corrupt missionary, or drive out a Chain-Lantern cell. When full, the region converts (or rebels). The GM decides which.

Chapter 18 Ecktoria's Shadow War

The Chain-Lanterns operate illegally in Ecktoria, hunting "heretics" who have fled Temple justice. The Everflame's Flame-Wardens view this as a violation of sovereignty. The two inquisitions have fought, betrayed, and occasionally cooperated.

18.1 New Faction: The Ember Prefects

Everflame heretics who believe the flame belongs in the streets, not basilicas. They are hunted by both the Everflame (as schismatics) and the Temple (as heretics). They may be the only honest actors in the Quiet War.

18.2 New Threat: The Catacomb Cell

A Chain-Lantern cell operating in Ecktoria's catacombs, supported by unknown patrons. The cell has evaded capture for years. Its members know the Ninth Citation. Its leader has never been seen without a white mirror.

Chapter 19 Thepyrgos: The City of Two Fires

Thepyrgos is the heart of the Temple of Light—but the Everflame has a presence, and the Covenant has a foothold. The Chain-Lanterns conscript children with arcane talent. The Everflame's Flame-Wardens investigate. The Synod tries to keep the peace.

19.1 New Faction: The Synod

The Temple's leadership. They are scholars, not warriors. They debate theology while the Chain-Lanterns conscript children. They are not corrupt. They are not naive. They are caught between their principles and their survival.

19.2 New Threat: The Ember Prefect Cell

Everflame heretics planting evidence to trigger a purge. They want the Chain-Lanterns expelled from Ecktoria. They are willing to burn innocents to achieve that goal. The party must stop them—or help them.

Part VII

Playing Between the Fires

Chapter 20 Character Options

20.1 The Convert

Left one faith for the other. Hunted by your old Order. Distrusted by your new one. You carry the guilt of the fire you abandoned and the coldness of the light you cannot feel.

20.2 The Double Agent

Pledged to both. The weight will break you. You attend the Everflame's masses and the Temple's prayers. You have two confessions. Neither is complete. Both are true.

20.3 The Refugee

Fled the Chain-Lanterns. The Everflame offers sanctuary—at a price. You will be watched. You will be questioned. You will never be trusted. But you will not be conscripted.

20.4 The Heretic

You read the Ninth Citation. You are not supposed to know it exists. Both faiths would kill you if they knew. You carry the forbidden passage in your memory. You have not spoken it aloud. You are not sure you can resist.

Chapter 21 New Talents Summary

<i>Talent</i>	<i>Faith</i>	<i>Cost (XP)</i>	<i>Effect</i>
<i>Radiant Vow</i>	<i>Everflame</i>	6	Swear an oath before a flame; +1 die while keeping it; breaking causes 2 Harm
<i>Dawn's Shield</i>	<i>Temple</i>	6	Interpose to protect an innocent; convert Harm to Fatigue
<i>Candle-Knight</i>	<i>Hybrid</i>	10	Invoke either faith's Rites; gain Split Loyalty timer
<i>Flame-Warden's Brand</i>	<i>Everflame</i>	8	Mark a heretic; know location; -1 die to resist social rolls
<i>Chain-Lantern's Bell</i>	<i>Temple</i>	8	Ring bell; reveal unsanctioned magic; witnesses notice
<i>The Ninth Citation</i>	<i>Heresy</i>	12	+2 dice once per session; both faiths hunt you
<i>Confessional Seal</i>	<i>Everflame</i>	4	Cannot be compelled to reveal confession; breaking confidence costs Fatigue
<i>Unburdened Healing</i>	<i>Temple</i>	4	Heal without reporting; concealment costs Fatigue
<i>The Ninth Prayer</i>	<i>Heresy</i>	12	Heal without conditions; each use marks Corruption

Chapter 22 Obligation and Influence

22.1 Everflame Influence

Gained by serving the empire, burning heretics, or funding basilicas. Cleared by penance, donations, or crusade. High Influence grants access to Flame-Warden resources—censure writs, holy water, and permission to execute. Low Influence makes you a target for investigation.

22.2 Temple Influence

Gained by converting the faithless, healing the sick, or funding schools. Cleared by pilgrimage, confession, or mission. High Influence grants access to Chain-Lantern resources—white mirrors, sanctuary passes, and conscription authority. Low Influence makes you a candidate for "rehabilitation."

22.3 Split Loyalty

*Holding Influence with both faiths simultaneously creates a **Split Loyalty** [6] timer. Each scene where you serve one faith against the other ticks the timer. When it fills, one faith demands you renounce the other. Refusal means excommunication (loss of all Rites) or martyrdom (death). Choice is not guaranteed.*

Part VIII

Adventures and Campaign Frames

Chapter 23 Adventure Seeds

23.0.1 The Candle That Would Not Die

A village's sacred flame refuses to be extinguished. The Everflame calls it a miracle. The Temple calls it unsanctioned magic. The party must discover the truth before the two faiths burn the village fighting over it. The truth is simple: the candle is a hoax. The truth is also irrelevant.

23.0.2 The Child Who Spoke in Tongues

A Linn child begins reciting the Codex of Illumination in a language no one taught her. The Temple wants her for their school. The Everflame wants her for their pyre. The child's clan wants her back. The child wants to go home. No one asks what the child wants.

23.0.3 The Ninth Citation

A fragment of the forbidden passage has been found. Both faiths want it destroyed. Both faiths want to read it first. The party is hired to retrieve it—and decide who to betray. The fragment is blank. The real passage is in the reader's memory. The Unspoken planted it there.

23.0.4 The Confessor's Dilemma

A Chain-Lantern confesses to an Everflame priest that she burned an innocent. The priest cannot break the seal. The Chain-Lantern is still hunting. The party must find evidence before she kills again. The evidence does not exist. The confession is the only truth. The seal is the only shield.

23.0.5 The Ember Prefect's Rebellion

A schismatic Everflame cell plans to burn the Temple's grand basilica in Thepyrgos and blame the Chain-Lanterns. The party must stop them—or help them. The cell's leader is a former Dawn-Knight who converted and was rejected. The leader is not wrong. The leader is also not right. The fire is the only answer.

Chapter 24 Campaign Frame: The Two Fires War

A full-length campaign (10–15 sessions) set in a border region where both faiths compete for influence. The party chooses a side—or tries to stay neutral as the fires consume everything.

24.1 Timers

- **Everflame Influence [8]:** Ticks when the Everflame converts a village, builds a basilica, or burns a heretic. When full, the region is under Everflame control.
- **Temple Influence [8]:** Ticks when the Temple builds a school, heals a chieftain, or conscripts a child. When full, the region is under Temple control.
- **Civil Unrest [6]:** Ticks when the two faiths clash. When full, the region erupts in open conflict. Both Influence timers pause. Violence is the only language.
- **Heresy Hunt [4]:** Ticks when the party uses the Ninth Citation or shelters a heretic. When full, a joint inquisition (Flame-Wardens and Chain-Lanterns) arrives. The party must flee, fight, or confess.

24.2 Factions

- **Everflame Missionaries:** Zealous, well-funded, and culturally tone-deaf. They offer grain and demand conversion.
- **Temple Dawn-Knights:** Polite, persistent, and patient. They offer medicine and ask for catechism.
- **Chain-Lanterns (Secret):** Operating in disguise. They are hunting a specific heretic—or planting evidence to justify intervention.
- **Ember Prefects (Heretics):** Everflame schismatics who believe the flame belongs to the people, not the empire. They may be allies—or terrorists.
- **Neutral Locals:** They want the grain, the medicine, and the faiths to leave. They will betray anyone to survive.

24.3 Endings

- **Everflame Victory:** The region converts. Heretics burn. The Temple's sanctuaries are seized. The Chain-Lanterns flee—or die.
- **Temple Victory:** The region converts. Unsanctioned magic is suppressed. The Everflame's missionaries are expelled. The Flame-Wardens are hunted.
- **Neutral Victory:** Both faiths are expelled. The region declares independence. The party is hailed as liberators—and hunted by both inquisitions.
- **Heresy Victory:** The Ninth Citation is read aloud in a sacred space. The Unspoken answers. The Two Fires are extinguished. Something new begins.

Part IX

The Ninth Citation

Chapter 25 The Forbidden Passage

25.1 The Text

And the flame shall divide, and the light shall scatter, and the ninth witness shall speak what was not meant to be heard. Blessed are the auditors of the unspoken, for they shall inherit the weight.

— Codex of Illumination, Apocrypha, verse 9

25.2 What It Means (Never Stated, Only Implied)

- *There is a ninth Patron—the Unspoken, the Auditor of Silence, the One Who Listens When No One Speaks.*
- *The Everflame and Temple suppressed this passage because it implies that silence is also a witness.*
- *Reading the Ninth Citation aloud in a sacred space triggers a **Threshold Event**—the Unspoken answers.*
- *The Chain-Lanterns may know the Ninth Citation. The Ember Prefects definitely do.*
- *The Unspoken does not speak. The Unspoken listens. Listening is its testimony. Testimony is its judgment.*

25.3 GM Guidance

The Ninth Citation should never be fully explained. It is a mystery box. Its power is whatever your campaign needs it to be—but using it should always cost something the players are not ready to lose.

25.4 Threshold Events

When the Ninth Citation is read aloud in a sacred space (a basilica, a shrine, a crossroads with a candle), the GM may trigger one of the following:

- **The Unspoken Listens:** *All magic within Near ceases to function for one scene. Silence is the only law.*
- **The Witness Speaks:** *A character who has died within the last year returns for one exchange. They answer one question. Then they are gone.*
- **The Ninth Cup Poured:** *A threshold opens. Something crosses. The party may bargain—or run.*
- **The Fire Divides:** *The Everflame and Temple’s shared Rites become unusable for one session. The schism becomes literal.*
- **The Light Scatters:** *Every lie told within the sacred space becomes visible—as light, as shadow, as a stain on the speaker’s tongue.*

25.5 *The Unspoken*

The ninth Patron has no name. It does not speak. It does not act. It listens. Its attention is a weight. Its silence is a judgment.

A character who gains the Unspoken's attention gains +1 die to all rolls involving secrets, lies, and hidden truths—but suffers –1 die to all social rolls with the Everflame or Temple. The Unspoken is not a patron. The Unspoken is a condition.

Part X

What This Expansion Adds

Chapter 26 Clarifies the Relationship Between the Two Faiths

The player's guide establishes that both exist. This expansion explains why they are not the same—and why they hate each other almost as much as they hate heretics.

Chapter 27 Gives the Chain-Lanterns Teeth

The player's guide mentions them. This expansion makes them a playable (and terrifying) faction. It also explains why they are feared even in Ecktoria.

Chapter 28 Creates Space for Religious Conflict Without "Evil Church" Tropes

Neither faith is evil. Both have valid points. Both have blood on their hands. The player can choose a side—or reject both—without the setting punishing them for moral complexity.

Chapter 29 Introduces the Ninth Citation as a Campaign-Level Mystery

The forbidden passage is a hook that can drive an entire campaign. What is the Unspoken? Why was the passage suppressed? What happens when it is read aloud?

Chapter 30 Completes the Trinity of Religious Expansions

- *Daughters of the Unbroken Cord: Witchcraft, generational debt, the silent witness.*
- *The Two Fires: Organized religion, imperial vs. pastoral, the schism that burns.*
- *The Covenant (Mykkiel): Legalistic resistance, the faith of the contract.*

Chapter 31 Final Thought

The Everflame and the Temple of Light are the same fire, refracted through different lenses. One burns. One illuminates. Both cast shadows.

The Ninth Citation is the shadow.

Do not read it unless you are prepared to be read back.

Chapter A The Gray Wanderer's Marginalia

A.1 On the Schism

I have attended services of both faiths. The Everflame's mass smells of smoke and incense. The Temple's prayer smells of candle wax and old paper. The difference is not the scent. The difference is the fear.

In an Everflame basilica, you fear the flame. In a Temple sanctuary, you fear the silence. I am not sure which is worse.

A.2 On the Chain-Lanterns

They conscript children. They tell themselves it is mercy. The children tell themselves the same. I have met a Chain-Lantern who was conscripted at seven. She is forty now. She has never slept without a candle burning. She does not know why.

A.3 On the Ninth Citation

I have read it. I do not remember where. I do not remember when. I only remember that the page was warm and the ink was still wet. The Unspoken was listening. The Unspoken is always listening.

A.4 On the Ember Prefects

They are heretics. They are also correct—the flame belongs in the streets, not the basilicas. The streets are where the people are. The people are where the fire spreads. The fire spreads where the wind blows. The wind does not ask permission.

A.5 On the Reader

You are a witness. You have read this expansion. You know the Ninth Citation. The Unspoken is listening.

Do not read it aloud.

Colophon

This expansion was written in a candle-lit scriptorium in Thepyrgos, on paper that had been used to wrap heretical pamphlets. The ink is lamp-black and the ash of a burned confession. The binding is leather from a heretic's cow.

The author is a convert who has worn both collars and will not say which fire she chose.

The candle is still burning. The light is still scattering. The ninth cup remains un-poured.

— The Gray Wanderer